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THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON

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MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telecon with Prime Minister Cavaco Silva of Portugal

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Prime Minister Anibal Cavaco Silva of Portugal
Interpreter: No
Notetaker: Anthony Wayne

DATE, TIME: June 28, 1992, 2:22 - 2:33 p.m.
AND PLACE: Camp David

The President: Anibal, how are you? (U)

Prime Minister Cavaco Silva: How are you, George? It's a great pleasure to talk to you. (U)

The President: I understand that you led the EC meeting to a conclusion that we should be doing more now on Bosnia. Our view is that we should go to the U.N., and we are willing to play our part. (S)

Prime Minister Cavaco Silva: The summit reached unanimity on sending a strong delegation to ask the Security Council for stronger action on Bosnia. I am sure the U.S. and the EC can press for more action, including military action if needed. (S)

The President: We are prepared for a resolution that authorizes whatever means are necessary to open the airport and get the food in. But we are reluctant to put ground forces in. Of course, there is plenty we can do to support this with our air assets and other forces in the area. (S)

Prime Minister Cavaco Silva: I decided to make this an important topic yesterday and to try to force a decision. (U)

The President: You weren't expecting U.S. ground forces were you? (S)

Prime Minister Cavaco Silva: No. The problem we faced was that France was prepared to send ground forces, but the U.K. was not enthusiastic. We decided to have the WEU study means of action to support the UN. We are giving priority to peaceful means, but we could support military means. First, the U.N. has to decide to act, but the WEU could be available to support it. (S)

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The President: I think there will have to be some ground forces as well as air transport and air cover. Some are also talking of a naval blockade. If military action is needed because the Serbs don't respect the ceasefire, then we will need peacemaking forces. The UN forces in place are not prepared for a peacemaking mission. We might have to force open the airport and protect the air corridors. But we want to avoid a situation like Vietnam where we get bogged down in a guerrilla war. (S)

Prime Minister Cavaco Silva: Yes, we are looking at a limited operation around the airport. If you are looking to Europe, there are those who are prepared to act with their NATO forces. Some may be prepared to send in ground troops. Italy and France were very strong in the Council, for example. There was some difficulty with the U.K., but I just heard Hurd on the TV and he said the U.K. was prepared to provide air support. It was just too difficult for all of us to explain why we were not doing more. (S)

The President: Yes. We are proud of your leadership, and we are doing the right thing. Our military people have their doubts about this. They are talking to the British military today. But be assured that we will support the U.N. resolution. (S)

Prime Minister Cavaco Silva: The EC is now ready to act. The situation was so bad that there was tremendous pressure to act. The Serbs and even the others just do not want to respect a ceasefire, so there was a great deal of pressure to act. Jim Baker put a lot of pressure on us too during the Lisbon meeting on Russian aid. Now, of course, we each have our own pressures. Mitterrand, for example, didn't inform us before that he was going to Bosnia. (S)

The President: Not even a mention? (U)

Prime Minister Cavaco Silva: No, he left the conference at 4:30, and we only knew when he got to the airport and was about to leave. He never raised it at the table. But the French pressed strongly for EC action. We decided not to recognize Serbia as the successor state to Yugoslavia and to suspend them from international organizations. This is pretty strong action, but it is time for even more. We asked France and the U.K. as permanent members of the Security Council to support military action if needed. (S)

The President: We will be there in the U.N. to support you. It was good to talk with you. (S)

Prime Minister Cavaco Silva: It was a great pleasure for me. It is time for the EC and the U.S. to go and do something together to solve this problem. (S)

The President: Well, congratulations on your leadership in this. Goodbye for now. (U)